Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Project

Stay Safe Online: Prevention Checklist for College Students in India

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🛡️ Prevention Checklist

General Online Safety

1. **Use strong, unique passwords for every account** Create passwords that are at least 12 characters long, combining uppercase, lowercase, numbers, and symbols. Use a password manager (like Bitwarden or LastPass) so you never reuse passwords across platforms.
2. **Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) on all important accounts** Turn on 2FA for your email, social media, college portals, and banking apps. Even if your password is stolen, attackers cannot log in without the second verification step.
3. **Never click unknown links in messages, emails, or social media DMs** Phishing links disguised as prize notifications, job offers, or college notices are a leading way students get hacked. Always verify the sender and go directly to the official website instead.
4. **Keep your devices, apps, and operating system updated** Software updates patch security vulnerabilities. Enable automatic updates on your phone and laptop so cybercriminals cannot exploit known flaws.
5. **Avoid using public Wi-Fi for sensitive activities** Public Wi-Fi in canteens, hostels, or cafés can be monitored by attackers. If you must use it, enable a VPN (Virtual Private Network) before accessing any personal accounts.
6. **Review app permissions regularly** Many apps request access to your contacts, camera, microphone, or location unnecessarily. Go to your phone settings monthly and revoke permissions that seem excessive or suspicious.
7. **Be cautious about what you share on social media** Oversharing your college name, hostel location, daily routine, or phone number makes you a target for social engineering and stalking. Keep personal profiles private.
8. **Download software and apps only from official sources** Use the Google Play Store, Apple App Store, or official websites only. Pirated software and APK files from third-party sites often contain malware or spyware.

💳 Financial & UPI Safety (Mandatory Tips)

9. **Never share your UPI PIN, OTP, or bank password with anyone — not even "bank officials"** Fraudsters often call pretending to be from your bank, NPCI, or government schemes. Legitimate banks and UPI apps will NEVER ask for your PIN or OTP over a call or message. Receiving money via UPI does NOT require entering your PIN — if someone asks you to enter your PIN to "receive" money, it is a scam.
10. **Double-check the recipient's UPI ID or QR code before every transaction** Scammers create fake QR codes or UPI IDs that look almost identical to legitimate ones (e.g., `paytm-support@upi` instead of an actual merchant). Always verify the payee name shown on the confirmation screen before pressing Send. For large amounts, send ₹1 first as a test.

🚨 How to Report Cybercrime in India

Channel	Details
National Cyber Crime Portal	cybercrime.gov.in — File a complaint online for all types of cybercrime including financial fraud, online harassment, and identity theft.
Cyber Crime Helpline	**1930** — Call immediately if you are a victim of online financial fraud. Early reporting can help freeze and recover lost money.
Local Police	Visit your nearest police station and file an FIR, especially for serious offences like cyberstalking or blackmail.

> **Tip:** When reporting, collect and preserve all evidence first — screenshots of messages, transaction IDs, email headers, URLs, and call logs.

📝 Project Reflection (100–150 words)

While researching cybercrime trends among college students in India, what surprised me most was how **sophisticated and targeted UPI-based scams have become**. I expected cybercrime to involve complex hacking, but the majority of cases involve simple psychological manipulation — fraudsters exploit students' trust and urgency. The "receive money" UPI PIN trick was particularly alarming: it is so counterintuitive that even tech-savvy students fall for it. What also shocked me was how underreported these crimes are; many victims feel embarrassed or believe nothing can be done.

As a result of this research, I will personally **change the habit of casually scanning any QR code offered to me** — whether at a shop, event, or sent online. From now on, I will always verify the payee name on the UPI confirmation screen before approving any payment, no matter how small the amount.

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